AN EXECUTIVE GUIDE TO ENGLISH THAT HOLDS TOGETHER

From Correct to Connected

For senior professionals whose English is grammatically strong, and who sense their ideas don't land in English with the weight they carry in Spanish.

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The gap nobody corrects

You can give an update in English with no grammar mistakes at all and still make your listener do the hard part. Three correct sentences: sales declined, we lost two distributors, we're launching a promotion. Across the table, your counterpart is working out how those facts relate. Did the distributors cause the decline? Is the promotion the fix for the distributors, or for something else?

Nothing in that update would be marked wrong by a teacher, which is exactly why nobody ever fixed it. The sentences are correct one by one and disconnected as a group, and the listener feels the gap even when they can't name it.

Senior listeners will do that assembly work once or twice. Then, quietly, they adjust how they rate the speaker. Not your English. You.

The good news is that connection is easier to learn than grammar. It comes down to two frameworks, and this guide gives you worked examples, the words that carry each relationship, and a short practice plan so you can use both in your next meeting.

> **Strong English isn't a collection of correct sentences. It's a chain of connected ideas.**

FRAMEWORK 1

Build the argument

Claim → Evidence → Explanation → Link

Claim	Evidence	Explanation	Link
The point you're making.	The specific fact that supports it.	Why that fact proves the point.	What it means for the decision in front of the room.

Most professionals deliver the first two and skip the third. The pattern I hear constantly is Claim → Evidence → New Topic. Your evidence does not speak for itself; it never does. The explanation is where your reasoning becomes visible, and your reasoning is what a senior audience is actually evaluating.

One more thing to notice in the examples below: the strong version never announces itself. It doesn't say "this evidence supports my point because." It just does the explaining.

Client call: protecting a launch date

CORRECT, DISCONNECTED

"We should keep the launch date. The reporting module is 40% of the remaining work. We can discuss phase two later."

CONNECTED

CLAIM We should keep the March launch date and move the reporting module to phase two.

EVIDENCE The reporting module is about 40% of the remaining development work.

EXPLANATION Keeping it in phase one puts the date at risk for the features your sales team actually needs in March.

LINK So splitting the release protects the date that matters most to you.

The before version leaves the client to work out why 40% matters. The explanation answers that before they have to ask.

Budget request to a US vice president

CORRECT, DISCONNECTED

"I need two more QA engineers. Production defects doubled this quarter. Also, the team is working a lot of overtime."

CONNECTED

CLAIM I'm asking for two additional QA engineers for Q1.

EVIDENCE Defects found in production doubled between Q3 and Q4.

EXPLANATION Every defect a customer finds costs us far more than one we catch in testing, in rework and in trust.

LINK Two QA hires is the fastest way to protect the renewal conversations we have in Q2.

"Also, overtime" is a second claim with no support. The rebuilt version drops it and finishes the first argument.

Email answering "Should we switch suppliers?"

CORRECT, DISCONNECTED

"I think we should stay with the current supplier. On-time delivery is 96% now. The other supplier is cheaper but needs qualification."

CONNECTED

CLAIM I recommend we stay with our current supplier for now.

EVIDENCE Their on-time delivery recovered to 96% over the last two months.

EXPLANATION That tells us the delays came from the port congestion, not from their operations.

LINK Switching now would add months of qualification work to fix a problem that has already resolved itself.

The before version hands over three facts and lets the reader choose. The after version makes the recommendation and shows why.

Why "furthermore" won't save you

When English feels choppy, the instinct is to add connectors: furthermore, moreover, in addition, secondly. Connectors describe relationships. They don't create them. If the logical relationship isn't there, the connector makes a promise the sentence doesn't keep, and that sounds more mechanical than no connector at all. Decide the relationship first, then choose the word that carries it.

RELATIONSHIP	SOUNDS CONNECTED, ISN'T	CARRIES THE RELATIONSHIP
Cause	~~Also, ... / And ...~~	...because... / ...which is driven by...
Consequence	~~Furthermore, ...~~	...so... / ...which means... / As a result,...
Contrast	~~On the other hand, ...~~	...but... / Even so,...
Concession	~~However, ... (to open)~~	Even though X, Y. / While X, Y.
Condition	~~Another thing is...~~	If X, then Y. / As long as X,...
Priority	~~Secondly, ...~~	Before we can X, we need Y. / That's why X comes first.

> The test: could you explain out loud why sentence two belongs after sentence one? If yes, a connector makes that relationship faster to hear. If no, the connector is decoration on a gap.

FRAMEWORK 2

Build the flow

Look Back → Connect → Move Forward

Look back
Name what you just established.

Connect
State how it relates to what comes next.

Move forward
Introduce the next idea.

This is the one to remember. Every time you change topic, in a meeting, a presentation or a report, the strongest transition does all three in a single sentence. The listener never wonders why you changed subject, because you showed them the bridge as you crossed it.

Three rungs of the same transition

Basic "Secondly, we need to discuss suppliers." Organized, but you have announced a new point, not connected it.

Better "Beyond the production fixes, we also have a supplier issue." The new idea now touches the old one.

Strongest "Production is stable, but stability exposed how much we depend on two suppliers, which is the real risk going into Q4." The relationship is the sentence.

Meeting: moving to the next agenda item

CORRECT, DISCONNECTED

"OK, the budget is approved. Next point: staffing."

CONNECTED

LOOK BACK The budget for phase one is approved.

CONNECT That covers the build, but it doesn't cover the people who will run it,

MOVE FORWARD which makes staffing the real decision for today.

"Next point" changes the subject. The rebuilt version gives the room a reason to care about the next subject.

Presentation: moving between sections

CORRECT, DISCONNECTED

"Those are our three growth markets. Now, pricing."

CONNECTED

LOOK BACK Those are the three markets where we're growing.

CONNECT What they have in common is that we're winning on service, not on price,

MOVE FORWARD and that's the reason for the pricing proposal I want to walk you through next.

The pricing proposal now arrives as a conclusion from the market data, not as slide seven.

Email: moving from one paragraph to the next

CORRECT, DISCONNECTED

"The contract is signed. Secondly, the implementation team."

CONNECTED

LOOK BACK With the contract signed,

CONNECT the main risk moves from legal to delivery,

MOVE FORWARD so the next step is confirming the implementation team by Friday.

One sentence closes the legal topic, names the new risk and assigns the next step.

Three full rewrites

The same facts in each pair. Nearly the same vocabulary. What changes is that every sentence picks up something from the sentence before it.

Quarter-end update

CORRECT, DISCONNECTED

"Revenue declined this quarter. Our largest customer reduced its orders. Inventory increased. We have a new sales strategy. We expect improvement next quarter."

CONNECTED

"Revenue declined this quarter, primarily because our largest customer reduced its orders. Lower demand also pushed inventory up, which is putting pressure on working capital. To address both problems, we've introduced a sales strategy focused on diversifying the customer base, and if execution stays on schedule, we expect performance to begin improving next quarter."

Follow the chain: the decline, because of the customer, lower demand, both problems, improvement.

Project status email to a US manager

CORRECT, DISCONNECTED

"The migration is delayed. The vendor delivered the API late. The team is working weekends. The new date is March 15. Please let me know if you have questions."

CONNECTED

"The migration will move to March 15, two weeks later than planned. The delay comes from the vendor's API, which arrived late and needed rework before we could integrate it. We've recovered part of that time by running testing in parallel, so the impact is two weeks rather than four. The one decision I need from you is whether we share the new date with customers now or after the first test cycle on March 1."

The new date comes first, the cause second, what you did about it third, and the decision you need last. "Working weekends" is effort, not information, so it goes.

Answering "Why are we over budget?" in a meeting

CORRECT, DISCONNECTED

"There were many changes. The client asked for new features. Also, the exchange rate. We are trying to control it."

CONNECTED

"We're 8% over budget, and most of that comes from scope: the client added two features in October that weren't in the original estimate. The rest is the exchange rate, which moved against us in the third quarter. The scope part we can recover, and I'm proposing we bill those features as a change order. The exchange-rate part we can't, so I'd rather adjust the forecast now than surprise you in December."

Number first, then the two causes in order of size, then what can and can't be recovered. A tough question is the moment the explanation step matters most.

A five-day practice plan

Ten minutes a day, using your own material. The goal is not to memorize the frameworks but to notice the gaps in your own English until you start closing them automatically.

Day 1	Open one email you sent in English this week. Mark every place where two sentences sit side by side with no stated relationship.
Day 2	Rewrite one paragraph from that email as Claim → Evidence → Explanation → Link. Read both versions out loud.
Day 3	Before your next meeting, write the one sentence you'll use to move between two agenda items, using Look Back → Connect → Move Forward.
Day 4	Find one "also," "furthermore" or "secondly" in your writing. Name the real relationship and replace the word with one that carries it.
Day 5	Record yourself answering a tough question you expect this month, in under 45 seconds. Listen for the explanation step. If it's missing, add it and record again.

Reference sheet

BUILD THE ARGUMENT

Claim → Evidence → Explanation → Link

BUILD THE FLOW

Look Back → Connect → Move Forward

Phrases that carry a relationship

- ...which is why...
- ...and that's what's driving...
- That solves X, but it exposes Y.
- The reason that matters is...
- Which means...
- So the real question becomes...
- Even so,...
- If that holds,...
- That's the context for...
- Once X is in place, the next priority is Y.
- That leaves one open issue:...
- The one decision I need from you is...

THE TEST

Did I state the relationship, or did I make the listener build it?

Doing this live is the hard part

Frameworks on paper are the easy part. The hard part is doing this in real time, when a vice president interrupts with a question you didn't expect and you have three seconds to answer in your second language.

That's the part I coach. Bring a real update from your calendar, and we'll rebuild it until the connections come out under pressure.

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